QUICK GUIDE: POTASSIUM & PHOSPHORUS

What every dialysis patient should understand about their labs

Educational content by Kiustin Guerra — trained as a physician in Cuba; now a dialysis technician and Water Preceptor in New York. Not individual medical advice.

■ Potassium (K)

Potassium is a mineral that helps your heart and muscles work. When the kidneys fail, potassium builds up in the blood. Very high levels can be dangerous for the heart, sometimes with no symptoms at all.

- General lab reference (MedlinePlus/NIH): 3.5–5.1 mEq/L. Your dialysis target is set by your care team.
- Warning signs: strong weakness, extreme tiredness, palpitations or an odd heart rhythm — tell your team the same day.
- High-potassium foods: bananas/plantains, oranges and orange juice, tomatoes, potatoes, avocado, melon, beans and nuts.
- Kitchen tricks: peel, cut small and soak potatoes and root vegetables; boiling them and discarding the water removes part of the potassium.
- Watch out for "no-salt" or "lite salt": it usually hides potassium. Read labels and ask before using supplements or vitamins.

■ Phosphorus (P)

Phosphorus works with calcium in your bones. On dialysis it builds up and, over time, can cause itching, bone pain and weakness, and affect the heart.

- General lab reference (MedlinePlus/NIH): 2.5–4.5 mg/dL in adults. Your dialysis target is set by your care team.
- High-phosphorus foods: milk, cheese and yogurt, cola sodas, processed meats, nuts, chocolate and processed foods.
- The "hidden" phosphorus: on labels, look for ingredients with "PHOS" (phosphate, phosphoric acid) — it is the most absorbed kind.
- If your team prescribed a binder, it works when taken WITH meals: it is part of the treatment, not a minor detail.

■ Your part at every treatment

- Show up for your lab draws: they are the snapshot of how you are doing between treatments.
- Write down your questions and bring them to your visit — understanding your numbers gives you control.
- No food is "forbidden forever": it is about portions, frequency and preparation. Your dietitian is your ally.

Want to understand ALL your numbers? Try "Understand Your Labs PRO" — kiusting.com · Salud PRO membership from $2.99/month.

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